the Red Cross were welcome on board Soviet ships heading for Cuba to make sure that they were carrying no weapons. “You must inform U Thant, for his personal information, that on those Soviet ships which at the present time are bound for Cuba, there are no weapons at all,” read Gromyko’s cable to the Soviet representative at the UN, Valerian Zorin. The instructions to Zorin mentioned nothing about U Thant visiting missile sites, but the Presidium decided to instruct Pliev “on admitting U Thant and those accompanying him to the sites.” Khrushchev was determined to have U Thant in his corner as he sought ways of making his deal with Kennedy stick.[24]

General Pliev received two cables that day, at least one of them dictated by Khrushchev. Unlike the verbose letter to Kennedy and the shorter but still substantial message to Castro, the instructions to Pliev, transmitted to him by Marshal Malinovsky, were curt and precise. “We believe that you were too hasty in shooting down the US U-2 reconnaissance plane; at the time an agreement was emerging to avert, by peaceful means, an attack on Cuba,” read the message, conveying Khrushchev’s displeasure with Pliev’s loss of control on the ground and putting him on the defensive. Then came an order: “We have made the decision to dismantle the R-12s and remove them. Begin to implement this measure. Confirm receipt.” The telegram was sent at 4:00 p.m. Moscow time. At 6:30 p.m., Malinovsky sent additional instructions: “In addition to the order not to use S-75s, you are ordered not to dispatch fighter aircraft in order to avoid collisions with US reconnaissance planes.” The Americans would be able to fly unobstructed over Cuban territory. Khrushchev was trying not to give any pretext to the “warmongers” in the Pentagon to undo his bargain with Kennedy.[25]

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THE LETTER TO KENNEDY COULD NOT BE SENT BY DIPLOMATIC channels, as Khrushchev was afraid of being late to accept the president’s offer and prevent war. He had the recourse of broadcasting it via radio, as he had done only two days earlier. Of course, a private message would have been preferable to avoid publicizing Khrushchev’s reversal of position about the